

Position Paper: Corrections Not Found – Post-Publication Integrity in Usable Security and Privacy Research

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Abstract—This position paper argues that Usable Security and Privacy (USP) research can only be as cumulative and trustworthy as its record of issuing and finding post-publication corrections, yet current infrastructure and norms make such corrections difficult to observe, evaluate, and act on. Errors are a normal by-product of complex empirical work, but when they persist silently in the publication record, they can compromise replication efforts, undermine evidence synthesis, and misdirect theory, practice, and policy. Drawing on a case study of major USP publishing platforms, we show that post-publication policies vary in clarity and scope, that basic descriptive statistics on corrections and retractions are not publicly reported, and that even when corrections exist, they can be hard to discover and may disappear when records propagate across platforms. We contend that these gaps are reinforced by a research culture that rewards novelty over correctness, limiting incentives to detect and publicly document errors. We therefore propose a coordinated agenda for post-publication integrity in USP: clearer and more coherent correction policies, systematic collection of correction and retraction cases in a public database, and point-of-use visibility via integration with existing meta-scientific services and researcher workflows.

1. Introduction

Errare humanum est. — Seneca

Errors during the scientific endeavor are normal. Some remain inconsequential, whereas others enter the publication record and thereby shape what is communicated to research communities and practitioners. Severe errors can, for example, mislead analyses, rely on erroneous data, or alter the conclusions drawn. Others may simply involve spelling mistakes, typing errors, and metadata inaccuracies introduced during the publication process. Importantly, many such errors can occur irrespective of intent.

The idea that science is self-correcting has long been discussed [1]. However, a possible lack of correction practices would warrant concern because errors in the published literature record can have serious consequences for the integrity of a research field [2]. For instance, errors can negatively affect the replicability of a field, with extreme cases distorting findings to a degree where there is no verity left [3]. Also, meta-analyses become meaningless if their

conclusions are driven by erroneous primary studies [4]. As a result of meaningless meta-analyses, no reliable evidence synthesis can take place. This will impact the validity of theories, practice implications, and policies that would rely on erroneous research. Resources such as time and funding might then, as a consequence, be used in suboptimal ways. Moreover, if the literary record is not corrected, young researchers joining such a field may cycle down the same path, advancing unreliable theories, drawing premature implications, and informing unwarranted policies [5].

A commitment to post-publication review, which might include the detection of errors even after a research project was published, is therefore essential to the integrity of the scientific process and to well-justified public trust in science. As these are generally recognized goals, the conditions under which they are achieved merit some attention. This means that although the self-image of science is that of an enterprise defined by the systematic control and correction of error, the serious pursuit of this goal is to be demonstrated by any given scientific area. The priority that a field grants to error detection might be gleaned from the tangible measures it has implemented toward this end [6]. In the absence of such measures, the prevalence of serious and even critical errors remains unknown.

To illustrate the significance of this question for Usable Security and Privacy (USP) research, a comparison with methodologically related fields might be helpful. Evidence from such disciplines suggests that errors are reliably brought to the surface when investigations into the methods and results of these areas are conducted. For example, researchers in various empirical fields admit to using questionable research practices that artificially facilitate the finding of statistically significant results, weakening the barriers against false-positive claims [7]. Moreover, systematic assessments of the numerical consistency of summary statistics reported in psychology articles has found that mathematically impossible values are widespread [8], [9].

In light of these findings, it is our position that error detection and correction should be seriously pursued within USP as well, rather than minimized, as is sometimes called for in related works [10]. The general consensus that errors occur in the course of the scientific process, and that a major goal of science is to correct them, stands in contrast to the question of which efforts are actually invested into this goal.

To the best of our knowledge, there are currently no data on error correction practices within USP. However, some indications can be gleaned from extant quality control practices in peer review. In a series of interviews with Program Committee members, about 90% stated that they evaluated submissions to high-profile conferences by novelty, while only about 43% reported evaluating them by correctness [11]. This might raise some concerns about the degree to which errors are detected and avoided during the peer review process. Traditional peer review is a key pillar of scientific quality control. However, once a manuscript passes this check, it enters the published record, from which it might go on to influence the broader literature, and possibly even policy. It is therefore important to enact quality control mechanisms even after completion of this process. We will now turn to such modes of post-publication review by discussing a case study on current correction policies of publishing platforms that publish, i.e., USP papers, their (lack of) reports on the frequency, and practice examples of correction occurrences. We chose to investigate these publication venues in detail since they are common and high-impact venues for USP researchers to publish in. We acknowledge that our analysis also includes general security and privacy and human-computer interaction papers; however, these may show a publisher's lived values that would also apply to USP papers at these conferences.

2. A Case Study on How USP Publication Venues Handle Post-Publication Review

2.1. Organizational Policies

Two of the well-known publishing platforms across USP researchers are the Association for Computing Machinery (ACM) Digital Library and the Institute of Electrical and Electronics Engineers (IEEE) Xplore. Both organizations host multiple outlets in the field of computer science and have issued policies that address the post-publication process.

The IEEE PSPB Operations Manual covers its publication principles in Chapter 8.2.1 [12]. These state that authors “have an obligation to correct errors promptly” (B8) and editors-in-chief “shall correct errors in an article if the errors are detected or reported before publication or publish corrections” (D8). However, with regard to post-publication changes, Chapter 8.1.10 A only addresses changes to the metadata of records, and B discusses retractions reserved for “publications that contain such seriously flawed analysis or erroneous data that their findings and conclusions cannot be relied upon”, while also stating that retracted publications should not be removed. Chapter 8.2.4 F2 allows for removal notices in rare circumstances. Thus, there appears to be limited clarity on how to handle errors that do not warrant retraction yet still require correction in the manuscript itself. As a result, mechanisms such as corrected versions of records or expressions of concern seem to remain largely unaddressed.

In contrast, ACM's Policy on the Withdrawal, Correction, Retraction, and Removal of Works defines five types of post-publication actions: (a) correction, (b) corrected version of record, (c) notice of concern, (d) retraction, and (e) removal. Corrections may take the form of an erratum, added as a title prefix “when a production-related error or omission by the Publisher has occurred”, or a corrigendum, typically issued via an editorial note “when an author has made a mistake or error and notifies the Publisher” [13]. Minor issues are addressed through a Corrected Version of Record (CvOR). From a researcher's perspective, the distinction between corrections and CvORs can appear unclear: both are intended to address minor issues, and both corrigenda and CvORs are initiated when authors identify an error and notify the publisher. An editorial note or expression of concern may be issued when credible allegations arise, for example, as the outcome of a formal investigation into misconduct or other substantive problems. Retractions apply to more serious issues such as plagiarism, failure to disclose major conflicts of interest, or clear evidence that findings are unreliable. Retracted works are not removed; instead, a retraction notice is shown on the citation page, the PDF is marked “Retracted” on each page, and the work is no longer presented with standard citation metrics. Removal is reserved for exceptional circumstances, such as unethical research or court orders.

To summarize, organizational policies on post-publication integrity vary in their level of detail across publishing platforms. Nevertheless, the overarching goal, i.e., maintaining the integrity of the scientific record through corrections and, where necessary, retractions, appears broadly shared. What remains unclear is the extent to which these mechanisms are practically supported in platform infrastructures (e.g., IEEE cases where errors other than solely those in metadata need changes), and to which degree researchers actually make use of them to correct mistakes once identified.

2.2. Silent Numbers

Hence, we were interested in the number of publications that indeed realize post-publication changes. After unsuccessfully searching for public reports of the ACM and IEEE publishing platforms on statistics concerning corrections, expressions of concern, or retractions, we contacted the respective staff involved in publication processes.

ACM was asked to give any insights into any statistics about retractions or corrections of ACM publications with a focus on CHI publications (Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems), as it is a flagship ACM conference with tracks on human factors in security and privacy. Their written response stated that they cannot share this data. IEEE was asked the same and, due to its size and rank, with a focus on S&P publications (Symposium on Security and Privacy). Their written response was that they also do not provide information on this matter.

The staff's recommendation was to explore and use a word search within their publishing platforms.

2.3. Practice Examples

We took their recommendation to heart and adopted an investigative approach to study (at least some of the) current practices, specifically regarding papers from USP. Although this investigation has a broad scope, it is exploratory in nature.

We searched the ACM Digital Library, filtering for research articles of CHI (“CHI: Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems”), a popular conference in the field of human-interaction that publishes USP research. We developed our search strings based on the terminology used in publication policies, together with our experience of the language commonly used to describe post-publication changes. Our search string included the following words: “erratum” (603 hits), “corrigendum” (0 hits), “expression of concern” (4 hits), “editorial note” (0 hits), and “retraction” (205 hits). The first fifty hits of each search, sorted by highest to lowest citation count, were checked for relevant occurrences. Hits were either not found in the paper PDF or HTML version or were explained by the paper’s topic. None of the results included any post-publication process. We then did some further investigation within the ACM Digital Library and found that other publication venues had retracted papers by adding a prefix to the titles, that is, “Retracted on.” Including this search string in our search strategy for CHI resulted in 0 hits. Aiming to identify concrete examples, we next queried for “corrected version of record” (5 hits; none concern USP research, applying the categorization of [14]). In each case, the record did reflect a correction: the HTML version contained an Editorial Note, and the PDF displayed “Corrected Version of Record” together with a version identifier and date at the bottom of the first page. The Editorial Notes described the changes as minor and provided the publication date of the CVoR, indicating that the earlier version might remain accessible via supplementary materials. Correspondingly, the earlier PDF version carried a “CVoR Issued” date and a DOI in the upper-left corner of the first page. However, contrary to the policy’s promises, none of these notices specified or highlighted what had been corrected. It does seem surprising that we identified only those five corrections in this database, despite it covering over 11,500 research articles published since 2008.

We searched IEEE Xplore and filtered for S&P (“IEEE Symposium on Security and Privacy”). Our search words were the same as for ACM and resulted in (full text and all metadata): “erratum” (6 hits), “corrigendum” (0 hits), “expression of concern” (0 hits), “editorial note” (1 hit), “retraction” (1 hit). None of the hits again were relevant to post-publication processes, except for the editorial note. This note regarded a non-USP paper and was provided by the authors after publication, on where to find updates on the topic, stated only within the PDF manuscript. Seeing some of IEEE Xplore’s other retractions and ACM’s CVoR approach, we also included “retracted:” (0 hits) and “- retracted” (0 hits) for within document titles, and “corrected version of

record” (0 hits) again for full text and all metadata. Thus, these hits did not provide any further examples.

For the USENIX Security Symposium, we searched the conference’s own website. Here, we find the PDFs of errata slips directly under the proceedings’ PDFs. We looked at the most recent publications from 2025 and used 2020 as a reference, as this is half a decade prior. There are five errata slips across both years, each covering corrections to one paper. The PDFs list any changes in detail, including page numbers and exact text changes. Each errata slip is also listed on the subpage of the respective paper. One of these five slips concerns a USP paper (following categorization rules by [14]), while the others are general security and privacy papers. In total, there seem to be five corrections of 564 accepted submissions for those specific years (2020: 157; 2025: 407). Still, when accessing these papers in the ACM Digital Library, there are no public indications of any post-publication changes. When we clicked the PDF link to “Publisher Site”, a PDF version of the paper opens that lacks the corrections and contains no statement pointing to corrections or other versions. So within ACM, the efforts undertaken by USENIX seem to disappear.

All of our search queries and results can be accessed via OSF (<https://osf.io/fbx3t/overview>) or are noted in the Appendix.

3. Recommendations on Post-Publication Integrity

3.1. The Role of Culture in Research Communities

It is our position that the main reason for the issues surrounding post-publication integrity is the predominant research culture in USP research and related fields. This culture prioritizes novelty over correctness and the number of published papers over their quality [11], [15], [16]. We argue that a shift in incentives is necessary to achieve a positive, constructive error culture that enables science to actually self-correct [5]. Crucially, such a culture must avoid penalizing researchers who openly issue corrections, as this could otherwise discourage transparency and disproportionately affect early-career researchers who are still establishing themselves and may lack strong supervisory support. An example of an initiative that aims to reward spotting mistakes is ERROR, a bug bounty program that pays researchers for finding errors in selected influential papers [17]. At the institutional level, agencies and research institutions may base funding and hiring decisions on the quality of papers rather than the sheer number of publications, thereby altering incentives. Calls for slowing down science in such ways have lately received more attention across scientific disciplines [18], [19]. To foster a positive error culture, tools that enable post-publication discussion of scientific work are also important. Here, we would like to highlight platforms such as PubPeer.

Of course, these changes require researchers to have the skills to spot the errors in each other’s work; a task that

is getting more and more difficult due to an increase in fragmentation of research fields [19], [20]. We therefore argue for more education, both in critical reading and in a field's diverse methods, not only during graduate studies but also continuing afterwards for all active researchers. We encourage the development and, first and foremost, use of forensic tools to aid error detection in the published literature (e.g., StatCheck, GRIM [9], or INSPECT-SR for systematic reviews in medicine [21]). Also, institution-level opportunities like journal clubs may encourage informal peer-to-peer learning in critical reading.

3.2. Towards a Post-Publication Integrity Process

We find that another fundamental step toward improved post-publication integrity is a change of policy. This is strongly tied to the role of culture, but more formalized in its nature. Policies should more clearly differentiate which post-publication actions are appropriate for which scenarios, for example, distinguishing errors in metadata from errors in the manuscript, and clarifying whether a change is initiated by authors, editors, conference organizers, or publishers. Moreover, the naming and categorization of post-publication actions should be coherent and, ideally, aligned across publishing platforms: labels should be descriptive, mutually exclusive where possible, and not so vague or overlapping that they become ambiguous from a researcher's perspective. We argue that researchers should be explicitly included in these processes, both in terms of understanding what options exist and in terms of being able to communicate their correction wishes under transparent procedural rules. For example, researchers might even want to discuss options of how to implement living documents, as those may have a lower threshold for correcting errors that researchers feel more comfortable with [22]. Researchers may similarly feel more comfortable with decentralized correction mechanisms, such as updates on personal websites or preprint servers, which could therefore be an important subject for future meta-scientific work. At the same time, because such changes often remain outside the official publication record, they may be less visible to readers and therefore important to consider in discussions of post-publication integrity.

In addition, stronger support structures for conference organizers should be considered as part of a post-publication integrity process in the USP literature. There might be cases, especially when problems are identified shortly after publication, in which authors are likely to approach conference organizers before contacting publishers directly. This makes organizers an important first point of contact whose role should be more explicitly recognized in formal correction workflows and policies. A post-publication process could therefore be refined by providing conference organizers with clearer responsibilities, procedural guidance, and communication channels for handling and forwarding correction requests. Doing so could help ensure that early error reporting is not lost in informal exchanges, but instead becomes part of a transparent and consistent integrity process. In this sense, ensuring that a full range of correction mechanisms

is formally supported (rather than only a narrow subset, or only under exceptional conditions) constitutes a necessary first step, particularly in venues where such options are not yet fully implemented.

As a research community, the next step should be to systematically collect cases in which post-publication actions occurred, including corrections, retractions, and related notices. Such cases should be saved and curated in an online database that is publicly accessible. Doing so would also enable the field to obtain basic descriptive statistics on these practices that are currently nowhere to be found. Such a database would constitute a first foundational step toward making post-publication changes easier to discover by allowing researchers and practitioners to more reliably identify in a centralized way whether a given record has been updated. Discussion on the practicalities of building, maintaining, and governing such a database should therefore be a priority.

We propose, as a third step, to actively involve other meta-scientific organizations, such as Retraction Watch. Retraction Watch has long-standing experience in documenting post-publication changes and in making such changes accessible to readers. Their role can also be understood as that of a broad, interdisciplinary, and external resource with considerable value for meta-scientific research on post-publication integrity [23], [24], [25], [26], [27]. In addition, the experiences of initiatives such as Retraction Watch can provide practical guidance on how to set up effective processes, including questions of implementation, timelines, and cost-efficient infrastructure. Building on such established expertise would allow the community to avoid redundant effort and accelerate learning. We advocate that, in this case, there is no need for the development of a novel technical solution.

As a final step, we suggest integrating our database approach with Retraction Watch. Concretely, this would involve regularly delivering our curated records to Retraction Watch while also integrating their services into our own literature search and screening processes, for example, via their database integration with Crossref's REST API. The goal would be to make post-publication changes visible at the point of use, that is, when researchers search for new literature and when they revisit their personally collected references in reference manager software. One practical implementation could build on Zotero's existing partnership with Retraction Watch by matching DOIs in a user's library against data stored on Zotero's servers, mirroring our database and displaying a clear warning or pop-up when a record has been updated post hoc. For USP research workflows, integration with LaTeX and Overleaf would also be highly useful, enabling transparency directly in manuscript preparation. Such a partnership would aim to serve our research community through the tools researchers already use, while ensuring that post-publication updates become difficult to miss and easy to act upon.

4. Conclusion

In our view, current post-publication practices are difficult for researchers to understand and to follow, difficult for the community to evaluate because basic descriptive statistics are not publicly available, and difficult to discover in the course of routine literature work, particularly when records move across platforms. As a consequence, researchers have little opportunity to experience error correction processes, even though errors can be an ordinary by-product of complex empirical work. How frequently such errors occur in USP remains an open question until the field invests more explicitly in meta-scientific investigation.

At the same time, errors warrant correction. Building on erroneous prior publications incurs avoidable costs in time and funding and can render subsequent scientific work ill-advised. For practitioners, the consequences can range from recommendations that fail to generalize at best to interventions that cause harm at worst, thereby undermining trust in scientific outputs on security and privacy. We argue that USP as a field should (a) systematically document and quantify post-publication actions and (b) make these actions difficult to miss at the point of use. This can include clear alerts during literature search, reference management, and manuscript preparation. Transparent, discoverable correction mechanisms would reduce wasted effort, facilitate cumulative progress, and, ultimately, strengthen the integrity of USP's scientific process.

Open Science

Data and analysis of the practice examples are publicly available at OSF: <https://osf.io/fbx3t/overview>.

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Appendix

A Examples of How Corrected Versions of Record are Handled in the ACM Digital Library

In Table A1, we list the 5 corrected versions of record identified in Section 2.3 that were issued within the ACM Digital Library for CHI publications.

ID	Year	DOI
1	2021	https://doi.org/10.1145/3411764.3445348
2	2022	https://doi.org/10.1145/3491102.3517647
3	2022	https://doi.org/10.1145/3491102.3517517
4	2021	https://doi.org/10.1145/3411764.3445276
5	2021	https://doi.org/10.1145/3411764.3445558

TABLE A1: Corrected Versions of Record at ACM CHI

B Examples of How Errata are Handled at USENIX

In Table B1, we list the 5 errata identified in Section 2.3 that were issued on the USENIX website for S&P publications for the years 2020 and 2025.

ID	Year	Link to Errata Slips
1	2020	https://www.usenix.org/sites/default/files/sec20_errata_1.pdf
2	2020	https://www.usenix.org/sites/default/files/sec20_errata_2.pdf
3	2020	https://www.usenix.org/sites/default/files/sec20_errata_3.pdf
4	2025	https://www.usenix.org/system/files/sec25_errata_hastings.pdf
5	2025	https://www.usenix.org/system/files/sec25_errata_kabir.pdf

TABLE B1: Errata for USENIX Security in 2020 and 2025